

Antigen	A substance in the blood that helps trigger the <u>immune system</u> to develop antibodies. See <u>blood group</u> .
Anti-inflammatory drugs	Medicines to stop or reduce swelling and redness.
Antiretroviral drugs/therapy	Medicines used to block the action of retroviruses (such as the HIV/AIDS virus) and the progress of infection. See also <u>HAART</u> , <u>HIV</u> and <u>retrovirus</u> .
Antispasmodic drugs	Drugs which relieve cramps or spasms of the stomach, intestines, bladder and womb (<u>uterus</u>).
Anus	The opening of the rectum to the outside of the body.
Arthritis	Painful and swollen joints.
Assisted birth (instrumental birth/operative vaginal delivery)	When special instruments (<u>forceps</u> or <u>ventouse</u>) are used to help deliver the baby during the pushing part of labour.
Assisted conception/assisted reproductive techniques (ART)	Treatments to help people conceive a baby. See also: <u>intrauterine insemination</u> , <u>in vitro fertilisation</u> , <u>intracytoplasmic sperm injection</u> , <u>donor insemination</u> .
Autoimmune response	When the body produces <u>antibodies</u> which react against the body's own tissues.

[Top](#)

B

Bacteria	Tiny organisms that may cause certain infections.
Bacterial vaginosis (BV)	A very common vaginal infection which results in discharge and soreness. It is caused by an imbalance in the types of bacteria in the vagina. It is not sexually transmitted and does not affect men.
Bicornuate uterus (womb)	A heart-shaped uterus. Usually the uterus would be pear-shaped.
Bile acids	Bile acids are made in your liver and they help you to digest fat and fat soluble vitamins. Intrahepatic cholestasis of pregnancy (obstetric cholestasis) is where you have a build up of bile acids in your body.
Biopsy	The taking of a small sample of tissue for examination.
Birth asphyxia	When a baby has experienced a reduced level of oxygen around the time of birth. Affected babies may not breathe normally and may have a low heart rate.
Bladder	The organ in the <u>pelvis</u> which stores urine before it is passed out through the <u>urethra</u> .
Bladder training	A way of teaching your bladder to hold more urine. It helps to reduce the number of times you need to pass urine and reduce urgency.

Top

Blood group	The way blood is classified by proteins (known as antigens) on the surface of your red blood cells. Group A blood has A <u>antigens</u> , group B blood has B antigens, group AB blood has both A and B antigens and group O blood has no antigens.
-------------	---

Body mass index (BMI)	A measurement to work out the range of healthy weights for a person. It is calculated by dividing your weight (in kilograms) by your height (in metres squared – that is, your height in metres multiplied by itself). The healthy range is between 19 and 25.
-----------------------	--

Brachial plexus injury	Damage to the nerves in a baby's neck.
------------------------	--

BRCA	The name "BRCA" is an abbreviation for "BREast CAncer gene." BRCA1 and BRCA2 are two different genes that have been found to impact a person's chances of developing cancer. Every human has both the BRCA1 and BRCA2 genes, which play an essential role in keeping our DNA intact. Alterations (mutations) causing loss of function in either of these genes are associated with an increased risk of breast and ovarian cancer. Mutations in BRCA2 are also associated with prostate and pancreatic carcinoma, melanoma and sarcomas.
------	--

Breech position	When the baby is lying bottom first in the <u>womb</u> .
-----------------	--

C

[Top](#)

CA125	A protein in the blood that is raised in
-------	--

	ovarian cancer. It can also be raised in endometriosis, pregnancy and infection.
Caesarean birth	An operation in which a baby is born through a cut made in the wall of the abdomen and the uterus. It may be done as a planned (elective) or an emergency procedure.
Cancer	A disease of the cells.
<i>Candida albicans</i>	See vaginal thrush .
Cardiotocography (CTG)	A machine which traces the baby's heart rate and the woman's contractions before and during birth to assess the baby's wellbeing.
Catheter	A small tube that can be passed through a part of the body, for example through the urethra (to empty the bladder).
Cell	The tiny building blocks which make up the organs and tissues of the body.
Cephalhaematoma	A bruise on the newborn's head caused by a suction cup being used to help deliver the baby.
Cervical screening	An internal swab test to check your cervix is healthy. It is sometimes called a smear test.
Cervix	The entrance or neck of the womb , at the top of the vagina .

[Top](#)

Chickenpox	A viral infection (also called <u>herpes</u> zoster, varicella or varicella zoster). If a pregnant woman catches chickenpox, it may cause problems for her baby.
Chignon	A swelling on the baby's head as a result of a <u>ventouse</u> birth. It settles within a day or so.
<i>Chlamydia trachomatis</i>	A sexually transmitted infection which can damage the reproductive system of both men and women if it is not treated promptly. Chlamydia is treated with antibiotics. Both partners require treatment.
Cholesterol	The name for a group of blood fats. It includes LDL, or low-density lipoprotein, which is 'bad' cholesterol; HDL, or high-density lipoprotein, which is 'good' cholesterol; and triglycerides (TG). A high level of cholesterol in the blood is a major risk factor for heart attack and indirectly increases your risk of stroke.
Chocolate cysts	Cysts which form on the ovaries in some women who have endometriosis. Also known as endometriomas.
Chorioamnionitis	An infection inside the uterus affecting the membranes (called the chorion and amnion) which surround the amniotic fluid.
Chromosomal abnormality	A different number or arrangement of chromosomes from the usual pattern.
Chromosomes	The <u>genetic</u> structures within cells which contain our DNA (the material that

[Top](#)

	carries genetic information). A normal cell contains 46 chromosomes. See also gene .
Chronic	Something that persists or continues for at least six months.
Clear margins	When no cell changes are present along the edge of tissue removed during treatment for cervical cell changes.
Clinical guidelines	Statements based on properly researched evidence which help healthcare professionals and patients to make decisions about medical care and treatments.
Clitoris	A small organ under a fold of skin at the top of the vulva . The external part is about the size of a pea. When a woman is sexually aroused it swells with blood and produces feelings of sexual pleasure when stimulated.
CMV	A common infection caused by the herpes simplex virus that is spread from person to person by bodily fluids (blood, breast milk, saliva and semen). CMV does not usually cause symptoms in healthy people, but if you catch it for the first-time during pregnancy it can sometimes be passed to the baby which can cause them to have health problems.
Colostrum	The first breastmilk produced during pregnancy and in the first few days after your baby is born.
Colposcope	A type of microscope used to see the cervix in detail during colposcopy. It has

[Top](#)

	a light attached and stays outside of the body.
Colposcopist, colposcopy nurse specialist or nurse colposcopist	A doctor or nurse who has completed medical or nursing training and continued onto colposcopy training.
Colposcopy	A hospital examination used to diagnose, monitor and treat cervical cell changes.
Complementary therapy	Treatments and therapies that are not part of conventional medicine. Examples include acupuncture, homeopathy and herbal medicine.
Complete miscarriage	When all the tissue associated with a pregnancy has gone and the uterus is empty.
Complications	Problems that develop after an operation, treatment or illness.
Consultant-led	A consultant led maternity unit is a maternity unit where there are specialist doctors (obstetricians and anaesthetists) as well as midwives, available at all times to look after you during your labour and the birth of your baby. There will also be neonatologists (doctors who specialize in the care of new born babies) available to look after your baby if they need additional support at birth. You may be advised to give birth in a consultant led unit if you have risk factors which may make labour or birth more complicated for you or your baby.
Conception	When an egg is fertilised by sperm and then starts to grow in the womb.

[Top](#)

Condition	A state of being, like being healthy or fit, or having a problem, such as a heart problem.
Confidentiality	The duty of health care professionals to not inappropriately share personal information disclosed to them in the course of their professional duties, by following the regulations regarding information sharing set out by the law and the General Medical Council
Continence	Having full control of the bladder and/or bowel. See also stress incontinence .
Contraception	Contraception, or birth control, is what you and your partner can use to help prevent an unwanted pregnancy or to space out your pregnancies. There are many different forms of contraception including condoms, hormonal pills and implants, hormonal and non-hormonal coils and permanent methods such as female sterilization or vasectomy. You can get more information about contraception from your GP or a family planning clinic.
Corticosteroids	A group of hormones which may be used to suppress the body's immune response or to reduce inflammation. Also used during pregnancy in women who are thought may have their baby prematurely. They reduce the chance of the baby having problems from being born prematurely. See also steroids .
Counsellor	A trained professional who helps people to make sense of feelings and issues.

[Top](#)

CTG (cardio-tocograph)

This is a machine that measures your baby's heart beat and your contractions by using sensors that are attached to your abdomen with an elastic belt

Cystocele

When the bladder bulges into the weakened wall of the vagina. A lump may be seen or felt.

D

Dilatation and evacuation (D&E)

Surgery using instruments to end the pregnancy.

Deep vein thrombosis (DVT)

A blood clot that forms in a deep vein.

Delayed cord clamping

Delaying the cutting of the umbilical cord for a few minutes, which allows time for extra blood to flow from the placenta into the baby.

Delayed miscarriage/
missed miscarriage/
silent miscarriage

A pregnancy that has ended although the fetus is still inside the uterus. Sometimes, because the fetus hasn't developed, it can no longer be seen and there is just a fluid-filled sac inside the womb.

Delivery

Birth of a baby and its afterbirth (see [placenta](#)). A baby may be delivered through the [vagina](#) or by [caesarean section](#).

Top

Depression	A common mental health condition, which is characterised by low mood or loss of pleasure or interest in activities for long periods of time.
Diabetes	A condition caused by high levels of glucose (a form of sugar) in the blood. The amount of glucose in your blood is controlled by a <u>hormone</u> called insulin. See also Diabatetes Type 1 and Type 2 below.
Diabetes – Type 1	A serious, lifelong condition where your blood glucose level is too high because your body can't make a hormone called insulin, which controls blood glucose.
Diabetes – Type 2	A serious condition where the insulin your pancreas makes can't work properly, or your pancreas can't make enough insulin. Insulin is a hormone that controls blood glucose levels. If you blood glucose levels are too high it can cause a variety of health problems for you
Diagnosis	The way a medical professional recognises a condition or disease.
Diathermy	A surgical procedure to heat up and destroy body tissue or stop bleeding. Also known as electrocoagulation.
Dilatation	The process of your cervix opening during labour.
Discharge letter	A letter a hospital doctor sends to a GP once treatment has finished telling the GP what has been done. The patient should be given a copy.

[Top](#)

Disease	An abnormal condition in the body causing harm.
Donor insemination	When <u>sperm</u> from a donor is put into a woman's <u>vagina</u> , <u>cervix</u> or <u>womb</u> to help start a pregnancy.
Doppler	A method for measuring the flow of blood, for example through the umbilical cord during pregnancy.
Dysmenorrhoea	Painful periods.
Dyspareunia	Pain during or after sexual intercourse.

E

Ectopic pregnancy	When a fertilised egg (<u>embryo</u>) implants outside the <u>womb</u> (usually in one of the <u>fallopian tubes</u>).
Early miscarriage	When a woman loses her baby in the first three months of pregnancy.
Early pregnancy assessment unit	A clinic that specialises in problems in early pregnancy (under 12 weeks) where a woman receives medical care, counselling and treatment as required.
Eclampsia	Seizures/fits that are a potentially life-threatening complication of <u>pre-eclampsia</u> .
Electrocoagulation	See <u>diathermy</u> .
Embryo	A fertilised egg.

[Top](#)

Emergency caesarean delivery	A caesarean delivery which was not planned during pregnancy. It is usually done because labour is not progressing normally or when the baby is unable to cope with labour and becomes distressed.
Endometriosis	A condition where cells of the lining of the womb (the <u>endometrium</u>) are found elsewhere, usually around the <u>pelvis</u> and near the womb.
Endometritis	Inflammation of the lining of the womb, causing discomfort or pain.
Endometrium	The lining of the womb (uterus).
Enzyme	A protein found in cells that speeds up chemical reactions in the body.
Epidural	An anaesthetic injection into the space around the nerves in your back to numb the lower body.
Episiotomy	A cut made through the vaginal wall and perineum to make more space to deliver the baby.
Erb's palsy	Damage to the nerves in the baby's neck (<u>brachial plexus injury</u>) which reduces movement of and feeling in the baby's arm.
Estrogen	A female sex hormone produced by the ovaries as part of the <u>menstrual cycle</u> . It encourages an egg to mature and prepares the womb for a pregnancy. Levels vary during the menstrual cycle.
Evidence-based medicine	A way of using reliable, objective, up-to-date evidence about how well different

[Top](#)

treatments or interventions work. It is also used to diagnose or predict the course of specific conditions.

Extended or frank breech

The baby is bottom first, with the thighs against the chest and feet up by the ears. Most breech babies are in this position.

External cephalic version (ECV)

Gentle pressure applied to the abdomen, if the baby is breech, by the obstetrician or midwife towards the end of pregnancy to help the baby turn in the uterus so it lays head first.

F

fallopian tubes

The pair of hollow tubes leading from the womb to the fimbriae near the ovaries. Each month one ovary releases an egg, which moves down the fallopian tube into the womb. The fallopian tube is where the egg is fertilised by sperm in natural conception.

Fecundity

Being fertile.

Female genital mutilation (FGM)

The partial or total removal of a woman's external genitals or other deliberate injury to her genital organs. It is illegal in the UK.

Fertilisation

When a sperm enters an egg and an embryo forms. Natural fertilisation takes place inside a woman's fallopian tubes. It can also take place outside the body, which is known as assisted conception. Techniques include IVF. See IVF and ART.

Top

Fertility	The ability to conceive a baby and, for a woman, to become pregnant.
Fertility drugs	Treatment to encourage the ovaries to produce an egg. It is used during treatment for infertility.
Fertility problem/ infertility/ subfertility	When a couple fail to conceive after having regular sexual intercourse for more than a year. 'Regular' is defined as two or three times a week.
Fetus	An unborn baby.
Fetal medicine specialist	A doctor who specialises in the growth, development, care and treatment of an unborn baby.
Fibroids	Non-cancerous growths that develop in the muscle (myometrium) of the womb (uterus). A woman can have one fibroid or many, and they can be of different sizes. Fibroids are sometimes known as uterine myomas or leiomyomas.
Fimbriae	The fern-like ends of the <u>fallopian tubes</u> , near the ovaries.
First-degree tear	A small skin-deep tear of the perineum during childbirth which usually heals naturally.
Flexed breech position	The baby is laying bottom first in the womb, with the thighs against the chest and the knees bent.
Folic acid	A B vitamin which reduces the risk of a baby being born with a spinal defect such as spina bifida. Ideally, a woman should take folic acid (400 micrograms) 3 months before conceiving. All women should take it for the first 12 weeks of pregnancy. A higher dosage (5 mg) is

[Top](#)

	recommended if you are overweight, on epilepsy treatment, are diabetic or are having twin/triplets.
Follicle	The part of the <u>ovary</u> where the egg develops.
Follicle-stimulating hormone (FSH)	Hormones which help the development of <u>follicles</u> during a woman's <u>menstrual cycle</u> and regulate sperm and hormone function in men.
Footling breech	When a breech baby's foot or feet are lying below its bottom.
Forceps delivery	Smooth metal instruments like large spoons or tongs which are used to help deliver the baby. See also <u>assisted birth</u> .
Fourth-degree tear	A tear during childbirth which extends to the anal canal as well as the rectum.

G

Gamma globulin (IgG)	A natural substance in the blood that protects against disease and infection. It is also used as a drug to boost immunity.
Gastroenteritis	Inflammation of the stomach and intestines, usually resulting in diarrhoea or vomiting.
Gastrointestinal	Relating to the stomach and intestine.
Gene	A biological unit which passes on inherited information from parent to child, like facial characteristics.
Genetic	Relating to, caused or controlled by <u>genes</u> .

[Top](#)

Genetic counselling	Discussions with a specialist to help you decide what to do if you, your partner or a close relative is found to carry an inheritable disease.
General anaesthesia	This is when you are given medication to put you to sleep during a procedure or operation. The anaesthetic medications are injected into a vein or given to you to breathe in through a face mask. You will be completely unaware of what is going on while you are asleep, and you will be monitored closely by the anaesthetic team throughout. You will wake up when the medications are stopped.
Genitals	The sexual organs: in a woman, the <u>vagina</u> and <u>vulva</u> ; and in a man, the penis and testicles.
Genital herpes	An infection caused by the virus Herpes simplex (the virus that also causes cold sores). It is passed from one person to another by skin-to-skin contact. See also <u>herpes</u> .
Gestation	The time between conception and birth, when the <u>fetus</u> grows and develops inside the mother's womb.
Gestational age	The age of the baby in the womb, measured in weeks from the first day of the woman's last menstrual period. A normal pregnancy lasts between 37 and 41 completed weeks, so a baby's gestation is usually around 40 weeks.
Gestational diabetes	A form of diabetes triggered during pregnancy.

[Top](#)

Gestational Trophoblastic Disease (GTD)	An uncommon group of conditions involving the placenta, which includes complete and partial molar pregnancies
Gestational Trophoblastic Neoplasia (GTN)	This is a rare form of cancer which can develop from a molar pregnancy or other forms of gestational trophoblastic disease
Gonadotrophin-releasing hormone agonist	A synthetic hormone-like drug which holds back the production of eggs.
Gonadotrophins	Hormones that help <u>ovulation</u> in women and the production of <u>sperm</u> in men. See also <u>follicle-stimulating hormone</u> , <u>human chorionic gonadotrophin</u> and <u>luteinising hormone</u> .
Gonorrhoea	A sexually transmitted infection caused by the bacteria Neisseria gonorrhoea or gonococcus. It is treated with antibiotics, and can cause long lasting damage in both partners if left untreated.
Graduated elastic compression stocking	An elasticated stocking which helps reduce swelling from deep vein thrombosis (DVT).
Group B streptococcus (GBS)	A bacterium that is commonly present within the vagina. However, it can cause a serious infection in a newborn baby. It can also cause infection in the womb (endometritis).
Guideline	Recommendations for good medical practice. They help patients and their medical teams make decisions about care (like those produced by the <u>RCOG</u>) and are

[Top](#)

developed by specialist teams who look at the best evidence available about care or treatment for a particular condition.

Gynaecologist	A doctor who treats medical conditions and diseases that affect women and their reproductive organs.
---------------	--

H

Highly active antiretroviral therapy (HAART or ART)	A combination of drugs used to treat people with <u>HIV</u> . It works by blocking the action of the virus and the progress of the infection.
---	---

Haematologist	A doctor who specialises in the diagnosis and treatment of diseases of the blood.
---------------	---

Haemolysis	Breaking down of red blood cells in the blood.
------------	--

Haemorrhage	Very heavy bleeding. In pregnancy it is called different names depending on the stage of pregnancy. It can happen: • Before 24 weeks of pregnancy (threatened miscarriage or miscarriage if the pregnancy is lost) • After 24 weeks of pregnancy (antepartum haemorrhage) • Immediately after birth (postpartum haemorrhage)
-------------	---

Heart palpitations	When you suddenly become aware of your heartbeat pounding or beating more quickly than usual.
--------------------	---

Top

HELLP syndrome	A combined liver and blood clotting disorder which is a complication of <u>pre-eclampsia</u>
Heparin	A type of anti-coagulant medication that is given by injection.
Herpes	A family of viruses which cause a range of infections including chickenpox (Herpes zoster or varicella), cold sores and genital herpes (Herpes simplex).
Herpetic whitlow	A painful viral infection of the finger caused by the herpes simplex virus (HSV), typically it presents as swelling, redness, and painful blisters or sores on the finger, and can also cause fever and general unwellness. While generally self-limiting and resolving within a few weeks, it can be treated with antiviral medications to reduce symptom duration and prevent spread.
High-dependency unit	A ward or area in a hospital that provides care for people who need intensive observation and treatment.
Hormone treatment	The use of hormones to treat disease or to replace hormones no longer produced by the body.
Hormones	Naturally occurring substances made in the body which control the activity of normal cells. They include: <u>follicle stimulating hormone</u> , <u>gonadotrophins</u> , <u>human chorionic gonadotrophin</u> , <u>luteinising hormone</u> , <u>estrogen</u> , <u>progesterone</u> , <u>prostate</u>
HRT	Hormone replacement therapy is the use of hormones to treat symptoms related to low levels of hormones in the body.

[Top](#)

Human chorionic gonadotrophin (hCG)	A hormone made by the <u>placenta</u> which is found in a woman's blood or urine if she is pregnant. May be used as part of <u>assisted conception</u> to help eggs to mature and to help an embryo attach to the <u>womb</u> .
Human immunodeficiency virus (HIV)	A viral infection which attacks the body's <u>immune system</u> , making it hard to fight off other infections. HIV is passed through contact with body fluids (blood, semen, vaginal fluid and breast milk).
Human papillomavirus or HPV	A common virus that most men and women have at some point in their life. In most people HPV will go away by itself without causing problems. A few types of HPV can cause cellular changes that may develop into cancer.
Hypermobility syndrome	Pain and stiffness caused by having very flexible joints.
Hyperprolactinaemia	A disorder which increases the normal level of the hormone prolactin. It can cause irregular periods and <u>fertility problems</u> .
Hypertension	Raised blood pressure.
Hypotension	Low blood pressure.
Hypothalamus	A small structure at the base of the brain which regulates body functions such as temperature and appetite.
Hysterectomy	An operation to remove the <u>cervix</u> and <u>womb</u> , carried out through a cut on the abdomen (abdominal hysterectomy) or through the <u>vagina</u> (vaginal hysterectomy). The <u>ovaries</u> can be removed at the same time if necessary.

[Top](#)

Hysterosalpingo-contrast-sonography	An ultrasound test of the <u>fallopian tubes</u> or the <u>womb</u> , using fluid injected through the
Hysterosalpingogram (HSG)	An X-ray of the <u>fallopian tubes</u> or the <u>womb</u> using fluid injected through the <u>cervix</u> .
Hysteroscopy and endometrial biopsy	A small operation which opens the entrance to the <u>womb</u> (<u>cervix</u>) to remove tissue from the lining of the womb (the <u>endometrium</u>).

I

Immune system	The way the body defends itself against infection, disease and outside substances.
Immunity	Protection against infectious diseases through the action of the <u>immune system</u> . You can become immune to some diseases by catching them. Vaccinations also provide immunity.
Immunotherapy	Treatment to prevent or change the response of the immune system.
Implantation	The process through which an <u>embryo</u> attaches to the lining of the <u>womb</u> .
In vitro fertilisation (IVF)	A technique where eggs are collected from a woman and fertilised with a man's <u>sperm</u> outside the body. Usually one or two <u>embryos</u> are then transferred to the womb. If one or more of them implants successfully, the woman becomes pregnant.

[Top](#)

Incomplete miscarriage	When a miscarriage has started but some tissue remains in the uterus.
Incontinence	Not having full control over the <u>bladder</u> and/or bowel. Problems with incontinence can range from slight to severe. See also <u>stress incontinence</u> .
Induction of labour	When labour is started artificially.
Infectious	Conditions which can be passed from person to person by micro-organisms like viruses or bacteria.
Infertility/ subfertility/ fertility problem	When a couple fail to conceive after having regular sexual intercourse for more than a year. 'Regular' is defined as two or three times a week.
Inflammation	A bodily response in which white blood cells and other immune cell protect your body from disease or injury.
Informed decision/choice	Providing enough quality information about a suggested treatment to help a patient decide whether to go ahead. This information must be balanced, up to date, evidence-based and given in a way that the patient can understand.
Infusion	A way of putting a drug or fluid into the bloodstream through a needle at a steady rate over a period of time.
Intensive care unit	A specialist unit within a hospital that provides extra care for seriously ill people.
Interstitial cystitis	Inflammation of the <u>bladder</u> wall.

[Top](#)

Intracytoplasmic sperm injection (ICSI)	A form of <u>assisted conception</u> in which a single sperm is injected into an egg.
Intrapartum	During birth.
Intrauterine contraceptive device (IUCD)	A small device fitted into the <u>womb</u> to prevent conception. Made of plastic and copper, it has one or two soft threads at the end which emerge through the <u>cervix</u> into the top of the <u>vagina</u> .
Intrauterine insemination (IUI)	A form of <u>assisted conception</u> which places sperm into a woman's womb through the <u>cervix</u> .
Intrauterine system (IUS)	A small T-shaped contraceptive device that is fitted into the womb. Made of plastic, it slowly releases the <u>hormone progestogen</u> .
Intravenous drip (IV drip)	Fluids put into a vein to rehydrate the body. Drips contain different combinations of minerals and chemicals, for example sugar and carbohydrate to provide extra energy.
Invasive	A medical procedure when a cut is made to the body or an instrument is inserted.
Irritable bowel syndrome (IBS)	A chronic disorder involving abdominal pain, bloating and changes in bowel habits, such as diarrhea. It is caused by an overactive bowel.

Karyotype	A record of the complete set of your chromosomes.
Karyotyping	A procedure to produce a karyotype using a blood or tissue sample. It is used to check for abnormalities in the chromosomes.
Ketones	An acid remaining when the body burns its own fat. It is often a sign of dehydration and can be tested by a blood or urine test.
Kidney	The body's two kidneys keep fluids balanced by filtering the blood. Waste products are then excreted as urine.
Klumpke's paralysis	Reduced movement in the baby's arm from damage to nerves in the baby's neck (see brachial plexus injury).

L

Laparoscopic ovarian drilling/ diathermy	A surgical treatment for polycystic ovary syndrome to improve irregular periods. Small cuts are made in the abdomen and an electrical current is used to destroy a tiny part of the ovaries.
Labour	The stages of childbirth. Labour is divided into three stages; first, second and third.
Laparoscopy	Keyhole surgery involving up to four small cuts in the abdomen. A telescopic microscope (called a laparoscope) is inserted into the body to help diagnosis or treatment.

[Top](#)

Laparotomy	A cut up to 14 inches long giving surgeons access to the abdomen .
Large loop excision of the transformation zone (LLETZ)	See LLETZ below
Late miscarriage	The unplanned loss of a pregnancy after 13 and before 23 weeks.
Laxatives	Medication to open bowels.
Libido	Sexual desire.
LLETZ	A common treatment for cervical cell changes that uses a loop-shaped wire to remove the affected area. Sometimes called loop electrosurgical excisional procedure (LEEP). See LLETZ patient information .
Local anaesthetic	This is anaesthetic given to numb part of your body for an operation and is an alternative to a general anaesthetic (where you are asleep for your operation). There are different types of regional anaesthetic including spinal anaesthetic and epidural anaesthetic. These are commonly used for caesarean births.
Lupus	A long term health condition which mainly causes joint pain, skin rashes and rarely kidney problems.
Luteinising hormone (LH)	A natural hormone released during the menstrual cycle to help stimulate ovulation .
Lynch Syndrome	Also known as hereditary non-polyposis colorectal cancer (HNPCC), is a type of inherited cancer syndrome associated with a genetic predisposition to different cancer

Top

types. This means people with Lynch syndrome have a higher risk of certain types of cancer

M

Major placenta praevia

A low-lying placenta entirely covering the cervix. See also placenta praevia.

Meconium

The poo that your baby does when they are first born. It is black and sticky like tar. Sometimes your baby can do a poo (pass meconium) before they are born. If this happens you may be advised to have closer monitoring during labour and your baby will be monitored more closely when they are first born.

Medical abortion

A way of ending a pregnancy by using medicines. See also abortion and surgical abortion.

Membranes

Another word for the amniotic sac.

Mesh

Mesh (sometimes known as tape) is a synthetic plastic product that looks like a net. It stays in the body permanently. A natural mesh can be created using a strip of tissue (fascia) taken from another part of the body, usually abdominal wall or thigh, which is also known as fascial or autologous sling.

Meningitis

Inflammation in the brain caused by a virus or bacteria.

Menopause

The time when a woman's periods stop, usually around 50 years of age. See

Top

	also <u>menstrual cycle</u> .
Menstrual cycle	The monthly process in which an egg develops and the lining of the womb is prepared for possible pregnancy. If the egg is not fertilised, it is reabsorbed back into the body and the lining of the womb (the endometrium) is shed. This is known as a period or menstruation. The cycle is controlled by <u>hormones</u> and on average a cycle lasts 28 days.
Meta-analysis	A way of combining and contrasting results from different studies with the aim of finding underlying patterns common to all.
Metabolism	This involves chemical reactions to generate energy for organs to work. It is a complex mechanism leading to making compounds such as proteins, fats, and sugars. This involves processes to remove by-products and is affected by many variables within the same individual and amongst different individuals.
Miscarriage	The unplanned loss of a pregnancy before 23 weeks.
Midtrimester	The middle stage of pregnancy, between 13 and 26 weeks.
Molar pregnancy	A rare condition where the placenta overgrows and the embryo does not form correctly.
Multiple pregnancy	When a woman is carrying more than one baby, e.g. twins or triplets.
Musculoskeletal	The body's support structure: the bones, ligaments, joints and muscles.

[Top](#)

N

Neonatal unit	An intensive care unit designed with special equipment to care for premature or seriously ill newborn babies.
---------------	---

Neonatalologist	A doctor who specialises in caring for newborn babies.
-----------------	--

Neural tube defects	Abnormalities of the skull or back bone of a developing baby that happen during the first 12 weeks of your pregnancy and which will affect your baby from birth. Taking folic acid before becoming pregnant and for the first 3 months of pregnancy can help to prevent neural tube defects.
---------------------	--

O

Obstetrician	A doctor who specialises in the care of pregnant women.
--------------	---

Oedema	Swelling in any part of the body.
--------	-----------------------------------

Oestrogen	See estrogen .
-----------	--------------------------------

Oligohydramnios	Too little fluid (amniotic fluid) surrounding the baby in the uterus.
-----------------	---

Oocyte donation	When eggs are donated to help another woman become pregnant.
-----------------	--

Os	The opening of the cervix.
----	----------------------------

Top

Ovarian hyperstimulation syndrome (OHSS)	A potentially serious complication of fertility treatment, particularly of IVF. Symptoms are abdominal swelling or bloating, nausea and vomiting.
Ovaries	A pair of organs (each about the size of an almond) in a woman's <u>pelvis</u> . They produce follicles from which eggs develop.
Ovulation	The process by which the ovaries produce and release an egg each month. Ovulation usually takes place around 10–16 days before a period.
Oxytocics	Drugs that stimulate the womb to contract.

P

Peer review	An assessment of the content and quality of a report or body of research by a group of individuals who have a range of expertise in a particular field.
Paediatrician	A doctor who specialises in the care of babies, children and teenagers.
Pelvic	Of the <u>pelvis</u> .
Pelvic congestion	Swollen pelvic veins.
Pelvic examination, bimanual/ internal	A check to feel the size and position of the <u>womb</u> and other reproductive organs to rule out any abnormality or problem.

[Top](#)

Pelvic floor muscles	Layers of muscle which support the <u>bladder</u> and other organs in the <u>pelvis</u> .
Pelvic inflammatory disease (PID)	An infection in the <u>womb</u> , <u>fallopian tubes</u> and/or <u>pelvis</u> caused by infections such as <u>chlamydia</u> and gonorrhoea.
Pelvic pain	Pain in the lower abdomen or pelvis.
Pelvis	The bony structure at the lower part of the <u>abdomen</u> .
Perineal tear	When the perineum (area between your vaginal opening and anus) tears during childbirth.
Perineum	The area of skin between the vagina and the anus.
Period	A bleed from the vagina between every 3 to 5 weeks which forms part of the menstrual cycle (see <u>menstrual cycle</u>).
Peritoneum	The tissue that lines the abdominal wall and covers most of the organs in the abdomen.
Pessaries	A medication or device which is placed in the vagina.
Physiotherapy	Special exercises and physical activities to improve body function and strength.
Pituitary gland	A gland in the brain that produces <u>hormones</u> .
Placenta	An organ which develops in the womb linking the baby with the mother's system. It is delivered after the baby, when it is known as the afterbirth.

[Top](#)

Placenta accreta	When the <u>placenta</u> is attached to the muscle of the womb and does not come away properly after the birth.
Placenta praevia	A condition where the placenta covers all or part of the <u>cervix</u> . If the placenta does not move sufficiently it may be necessary to perform a caesarean. See also <u>major placenta praevia</u> .
Platelets	Specialised cells necessary for blood clotting.
Polycystic ovaries	<u>Ovaries</u> which have at least twice as many developing follicles as normal ovaries in the early part of the menstrual cycle.
Polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS)	A condition which can affect a woman's menstrual cycle, fertility, hormones and aspects of her appearance. It can also affect long-term health.
Polyhydramnios	Too much fluid (amniotic fluid) surrounding the baby in the uterus.
Polyp	A growth of tissue arising from the lining layer of an organ of your body. Polyps can grow in many different places, for example, cervix, uterus, bowel, inside of nose, skin.
Post-mortem	A medical examination of the body to find a cause of death.
Postnatal	The baby's condition after birth.
Postnatal depression	A type of depression parents have after the birth of their baby/babies.
Postpartum	The mother's condition after childbirth.

[Top](#)

Postpartum haemorrhage	Heavy blood loss after the delivery of the baby.
Pre-eclampsia (also known as toxemia)	A condition that occurs in the second half of pregnancy, associated with high blood pressure and protein in the urine.
Pregnancy test	A test on a sample of urine or blood to confirm whether a woman is pregnant. The test works by detecting the presence of a pregnancy hormone.
Premature birth / Preterm birth	When your baby is born before 37 completed weeks of pregnancy.
Preterm labour	Labour that happens before 37 weeks of pregnancy.
Preterm premature rupture of membranes	When a pregnant woman's waters break before 37 weeks of pregnancy.
Progesterone	A hormone produced as a result of <u>ovulation</u> . It prepares the lining of the womb to enable a fertilised egg to implant there.
Progestogen	A synthetic <u>hormone</u> , similar to <u>progesterone</u> . It thickens the mucus around the <u>cervix</u> , making it difficult for <u>sperm</u> to get into the <u>womb</u> or for a fertilised egg to implant in the womb.
Prolactin	The <u>hormone</u> which is responsible for producing breast milk.
Prolapse	Where the <u>bladder</u> , <u>womb</u> or bowel pushes through the wall of the <u>vagina</u> .
Prostaglandin	The <u>hormone</u> that makes

[Top](#)

	the <u>womb</u> contract during labour. Synthetic prostaglandins can be used to induce labour or in <u>medical abortion</u> to end a pregnancy.
Proteinuria	Protein in the urine.
Pubic, pubis	The area around the bone at the front of the <u>pelvis</u> .
Pudendal block	A local anaesthetic injection inside the vagina.
Pulmonary embolus	Part of a blood clot (DVT) which breaks off and travels in the blood stream and becomes stuck in the lung.

R

Randomised controlled trial (RCT)	A study which tests the effectiveness and safety of treatments or procedures as fairly and objectively as possible. By randomly assigning patients to different treatments for the same problem, the results can be assessed equally with the aim of discovering the best possible procedure for the condition.
Rectocele	When the rectum bulges into the weakened wall of the vagina. A lump may be seen or felt.
Rectum	The part of the large intestine which stores solid waste until it leaves the body through the anus.
Recurrent miscarriage	When a woman loses three or more babies before 23 completed weeks.
Reproductive	The parts of the male and female body

[Top](#)

organs	needed to create and sustain a pregnancy.
Reproductive years	In women, the time from the start of menstrual periods (menarche) to the menopause.
Retrovirus	A type of virus. HIV is a retrovirus. See also HAART and antiretroviral therapy .
RhD antigen	A protein on the red blood cells of 85% of people in the UK. These people are known as RhD positive. People who do not have the protein are described as RhD negative. See also blood group .
Risk	The chance that an activity or hazard will give rise to harm. Risk is generally given in terms of numerical odds (1 in 10) or percentages (10%).
Royal College of Obstetricians and Gynaecologists (RCOG)	We are the professional body who oversee the medical education, training and examination of obstetricians and gynaecologists in the UK and many places overseas. We set internationally recognised standards and produce clinical guidelines for treatment and care.
Rupture of membranes	The medical term for the breaking of waters in pregnancy.

S

Sanitary pad	A disposable pad of absorbent material used to collect blood during menstruation and after childbirth.
--------------	--

[Top](#)

Scientific evidence	Information gathered in a systematic way to confirm or disprove a particular idea. Growing understanding may result in established practices being changed.
Screening	A test or set of tests to check for a condition in a person who shows no symptoms, but who may be at risk (perhaps because of their age or sexual behaviour, for example).
Second-degree tear	A tear during childbirth which affects the muscle of the perineum as well as the skin, and usually requiring stitches.
Second stage of labour	The period when the cervix is fully dilated until the birth. This is the time when the woman will start pushing.
Sedation	This is when you are given medications to make you feel more relaxed and comfortable during a procedure. This is usually given into your vein (intravenously) but can sometimes be taken by mouth (oral) or breathed in through a face mask. You will be awake but sleepy, depending on how much sedation you are given. You should not work, look after children or others, drive, cook, operate machinery or make any important decisions for 24 hours after the procedure to allow time for the medications to leave your body.
'See and treat'	A phrase sometimes used to describe treatment being offered at a first colposcopy appointment.
Semen	The fluid that contains <u>sperm</u> .
Sepsis	The immune system's overreaction to an infection or injury which can lead to tissue damage, organ failure, and death.

Top

Severe pre-eclampsia	When pre-eclampsia has progressed and treatment is required or the baby needs to be delivered.
Sexually transmitted infection (STI)	An infection that is passed on through close physical contact during sex. Some STIs have no symptoms, so it is important to be tested if you think you have been at risk. See also chlamydia , genital herpes and HIV .
Shoulder dystocia	A situation during birth when the baby's head has been born but one of the shoulders becomes stuck behind the mother's pelvic bone, preventing the birth of the baby's body.
Sickle cell disease (SCD)	An inherited condition in which red blood cells, which carry oxygen around the body, develop abnormally.
Skin to skin contact	Having your baby on you with their naked skin next to yours. This helps with temperature control, establishing breast feeding and bonding with your new baby
Sonographer	A healthcare professional who uses ultrasound equipment to scan your baby to in order to check their growth and development
Special care baby unit	A specialist unit in a hospital to care for premature babies.
Speculum	A plastic or metal instrument used to separate the walls of the vagina to show or reach the cervix.
Sperm	The male reproductive cell which fertilises a woman's eggs. Men usually have millions of sperm in their semen.
Spina bifida	A condition which affects the unborn baby in

[Top](#)

	the early stages of pregnancy. Spina bifida causes damage to the spinal cord and nerves.
Spinal anaesthesia	An anaesthetic injection into the lower back that numbs the lower body so surgery can be carried out in this area without you feeling any pain.
Spontaneous vaginal birth	The natural birth of a baby through the vaginal canal without assistance.
Sporadic	A 'one-off' event.
Sterilisation	Permanent contraception for women (see tubal occlusion) and men (see vasectomy).
Steroids	A group of natural or synthetic hormones. See also corticosteroids .
Stillbirth	When a baby is born dead after the 23rd completed week of pregnancy.
Stool (or faeces)	The waste matter discharged in a bowel movement.
Stress incontinence	Leaking urine during everyday activities like coughing, laughing or exercising. This usually happens because the muscles that support the bladder are too weak.
Succentorial lobe	An additional piece of placenta connected by membranes.
Surgical abortion	A type of abortion using suction instruments or D&E to end a pregnancy. See also abortion and medical abortion .
Sutures	Stitches which may dissolve, or remain within the body permanently.

[Top](#)

Symphysis fundal height	A measure of the size of the <u>uterus</u> used to monitor a baby's growth and development during pregnancy.
Symptom	A specific medical sign of a condition, illness or disease.
Syndrome	A collection of different signs and symptoms that are all part of the same underlying medical condition.
Systematic review	A review of evidence from a number of studies on a particular topic. The review uses standardised methods to analyse results and assess conclusions

T

Thrombophilia	A blood clotting abnormality which tends to run in families, whereby the blood is more likely to clot than usual.
Tachycardia	A rapid heart beat.
Tampon	A tube of absorbent material that fits into the vagina to absorb the menstrual blood.
Temperature	The degree of hotness or coldness of a body or an environment.
Term	Between 37 and 42 weeks of pregnancy.
Testosterone	A male hormone that occurs in small amounts in women and can be used as a part of hormone replacement therapy

[Top](#)

Third-degree tear	A tear during childbirth which extends downwards from the vaginal wall and perineum to the anal sphincter, the muscle that controls the anus.
Threatened miscarriage	Bleeding before 24 weeks of pregnancy which occurs without harm to the baby.
Thrombosis	A clot in a blood vessel.
Thrush	See vaginal thrush .
To open bowels	To go to the toilet to pass solid waste.
Tocolysis	Treatments used to delay or prevent early labour.
Toxaemia	See pre-eclampsia .
Toxoplasmosis	A common infection caused by a parasite which can be found in undercooked meats and the poo of infected cats. It can also be found in soil that has been contaminated by cat poo, and in unpasteurised goat's milk, or caught by handling pregnant sheep and lambs. Usually it does not cause any symptoms, but can cause a flu-like illness. It can cause serious problems if you have a weakened immune system, or catch it for the first time during pregnancy. In pregnancy it can cause miscarriage or health problems for the baby. It can be treated with antibiotics.
Transabdominal scan	A scan where the probe is moved across the abdomen .
Transvaginal scan	A scan where the probe is placed inside the vagina .

Top

Transverse position	When the baby is lying across the <u>womb</u> .
Trimester	A three-month period of time. Pregnancy is divided into three trimesters: • First trimester – up to around 13 weeks • Second trimester – to around 13 to 26 weeks • Third trimester – around 27 to 40 weeks
Tubal occlusion	An operation which blocks, seals or cuts the <u>fallopian tubes</u> . Also known as <u>sterilisation</u> . It is a permanent method of contraception for women.

U

Ultrasound	High-frequency sound waves used to provide images of the body, tissues and internal organs.
Umbilical cord (umbilicus)	The cord that connects a mother's blood system with a baby's (through its navel) and which is cut after the birth.
Urethra	The tube through which urine empties out of the <u>bladder</u> .
Urethracele	When the tissues that hold the <u>urethra</u> in place weaken, causing it to move and put pressure on the <u>vagina</u> , sometimes pushing through the wall of the vagina.
Urine	Excreted fluids containing waste products of the body.

[Top](#)

Urodynamics	Tests to assess how the <u>bladder</u> is working.
Uterine rupture	This is when the muscle of your uterus (womb) tears, usually because of contractions while you are in labour. It is rare but more common if you have had previous operations on your uterus including caesarean births. It is an emergency affecting both you and your baby and if it happens you are likely to need an emergency caesarean birth.
Uterine sarcoma	A disease in which malignant (cancer) cells form in the muscles of the uterus or other tissues that support the uterus, rather than the lining of the womb, as in the case of uterine carcinoma.
Uterus (also known as <u>womb</u>)	The organ where a baby develops during pregnancy. Made of muscle, it is hollow, stretchy and about the size and shape of an upside-down pear. It sits between the <u>bladder</u> and the rectum in a woman's <u>pelvis</u> .

V

Vagina	The canal leading from the <u>vulva</u> to the <u>cervix</u> .
Vaginal discharge	Any vaginal secretion except menstrual bleeding.
(Normal) vaginal discharge	A clear or whitish fluid that comes from the vagina or cervix.

[Top](#)

(Abnormal) vaginal discharge	An abnormal smelling yellow or green discharge which should be assessed by a doctor.
Vaginal examination – internal	A check to feel the size and position of the vagina and <u>cervix</u> to check there isn't any abnormality or problem. This may be carried out using a <u>speculum</u> .
Vaginal swab	Similar to a cotton bud, but smaller and rounder. Some have a small plastic loop at the end instead of a cotton tip. It is wiped over the vagina to collect samples of fluid to check for infection.
Vaginal thrush	An infection caused by a yeast known as <i>Candida albicans</i> . Symptoms include redness and itching around the genital area and unusual vaginal discharge.
Varicella	The medical name for chickenpox. See <u>chickenpox</u> .
Vas deferens	The tube which carries <u>sperm</u> from the testicles to the penis.
Vasectomy	A permanent method of contraception for men. It blocks, seals or cuts the tube (the <u>vas deferens</u>) which carries <u>sperm</u> from the testicles to the penis. Also known as sterilisation.
Vein	A blood vessel that takes blood towards the heart.
Velamentous cord insertion	Normally the umbilical cord inserts into the centre of the placenta. Velamentous cord insertion is when it runs through the membranes before reaching the placenta
Venous	A blood clot that forms in a vein.

[Top](#)

thrombosis

Ventouse delivery	A way of helping deliver a baby by using suction through a special cup placed on the baby's head.
-------------------	---

Virus	A micro-organism which invades living cells in order to grow or reproduce. Viruses cause many infections, from the common cold, chickenpox and measles to HIV .
-------	---

Vulva	The area surrounding the opening of the vagina. It includes the inner and outer vaginal lips (the labia) and the clitoris .
-------	---

W

Weak cervix	When the cervix (the neck of the womb) opens too early in pregnancy, in the second trimester , and without contractions. Used to be known as 'incompetent cervix'.
-------------	--

White cell	Cells in the lymphatic and blood systems of the body which fight infection. They are part of the body's immune system.
------------	--

White cell count	A count to measure the number of white blood cells.
------------------	---

Womb	See uterus .
------	------------------------------

Top